

General Knowledge

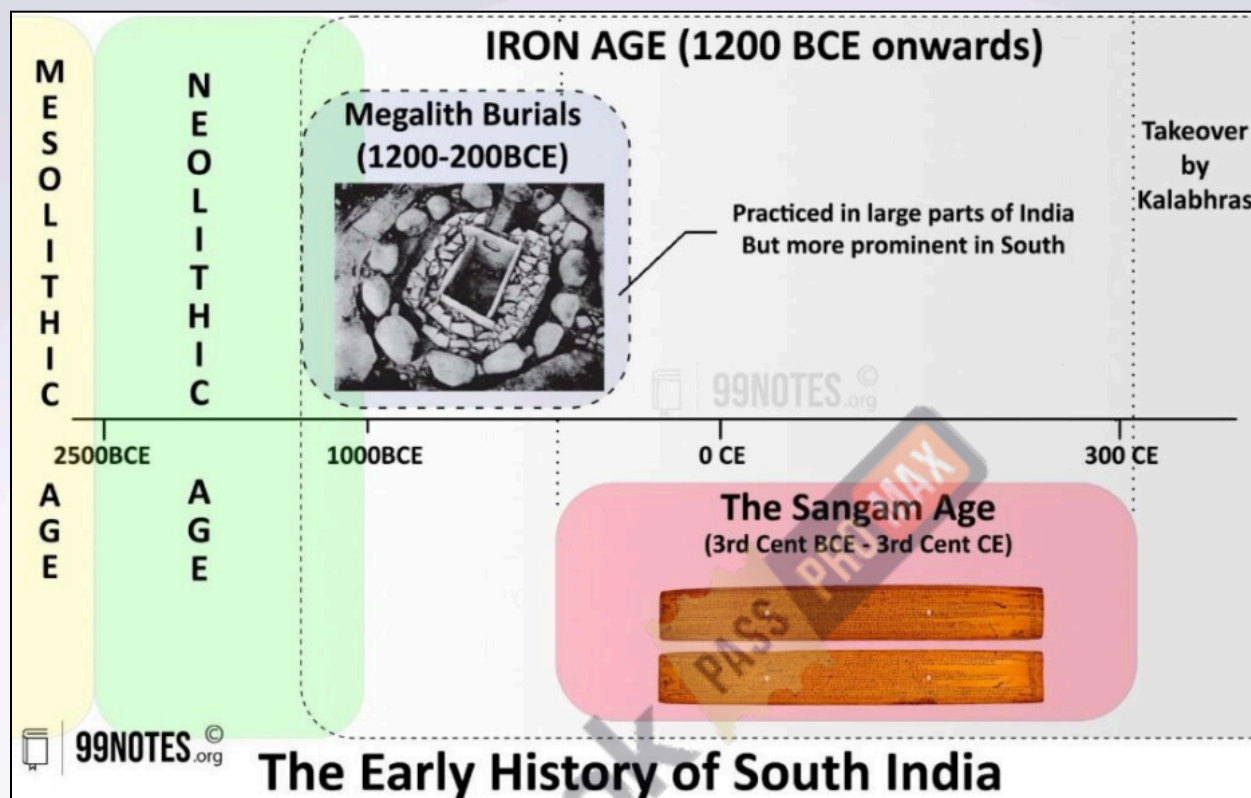
Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Cholas, Cheras & Pandyas



Sangam Age - Cholas, Cheras & Pandyas



Introduction to the Sangam Age

- The **Sangam Age** refers to the period between **300 BCE to 300 CE** in **South India**, characterized by the development of **Tamil literature** and flourishing political, economic, and social structures.
- The word '**Sangam**' refers to **gatherings or assemblies** of poets and scholars under royal patronage.
- **Three Sangams (Muchchangam)** are believed to have been held to promote **Tamil language and literature**.
- **Primary Sources:** Sangam literature such as **Tolkappiyam**, **Ettuthokai (Eight Anthologies)**, **Pattuppattu (Ten Idylls)**, epics like **Silappathikaram** and **Manimekalai**, and **archaeological remains** provide insights into this era.

Sangam Assemblies (Muchchangam)

Sangam	Location	Presided by	Notable Works	Attended by	Outcome/Impact
First Sangam	Madurai	Agastya (Agattiyar)	No surviving work; Agayattiyam is believed to have been composed	Gods, sages, legendary figures	Foundation of Tamil literature
Second Sangam	Kapadapuram	Tolkappiyar	Tolkappiyam (earliest Tamil grammar)	Kings, poets	Laid rules for Tamil grammar
Third Sangam	Madurai	Nakkirar	Eight anthologies (Ettuthokai) , Ten Idylls (Pattuppattu)	Numerous poets, including Avvaiyar	Development of Tamil literature, Epics

Sangam Literature

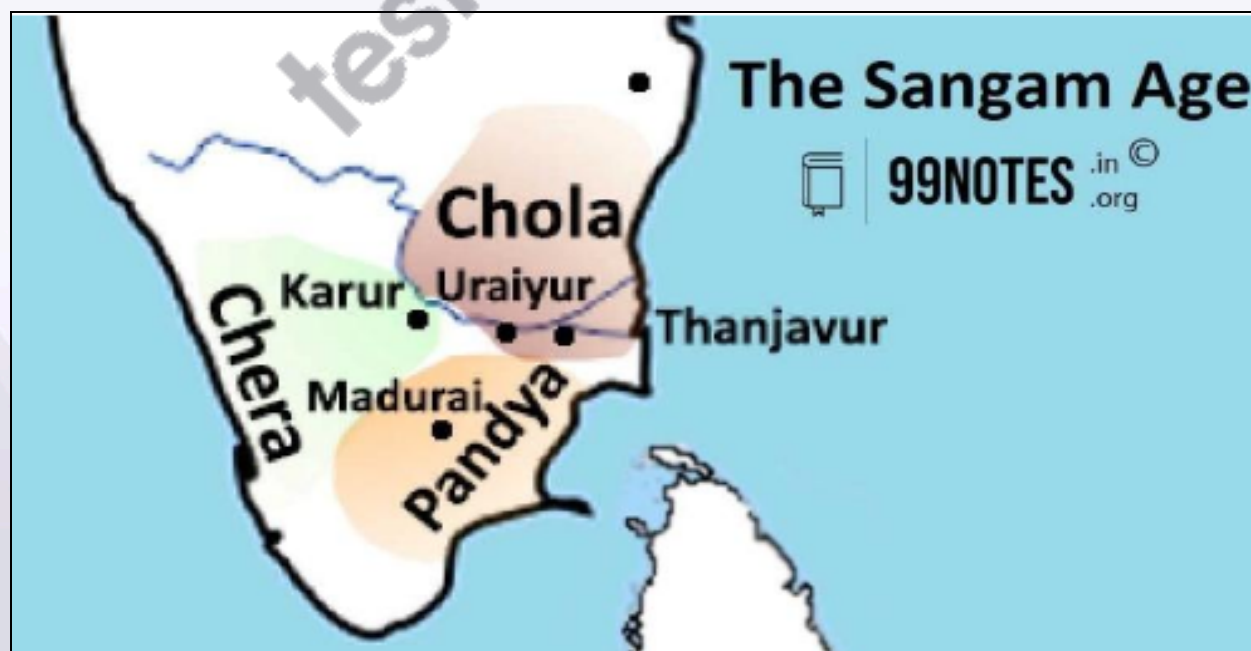
Category	Work	Author(s)	Themes and Features
Early Sangam Literature	Tolkappiyam	Tolkappiyar	A text on Tamil grammar also discusses the political, social, and economic conditions of the Sangam period.
Narrative Texts	Ettutogai (Eight Anthologies)	Kapilar, Nakkirar, and Auvaiyar, etc.	- Praises love heroism, and valor of kings. - Reflects on the society, lifestyle, and traditions of Tamil people.

Narrative Texts	Pattuppattu (Ten Long Poems)	Multiple poets	• Focuses on heroic deeds, kingship, and glory. • Provides insight into Sangam society and culture.
Didactic Texts	Pathinenkil-k anakku (Eighteen Lesser Works)	Multiple authors	• Includes moral and ethical texts. • Tirukkural by Thiruvalluvar is the most significant work on ethics and morality.
Epic	Silappathikaram	Ilango Adigal	• It depicts the devotion of Kannagi to her husband Kovalan. • Explores themes of love, betrayal, and justice. • Highlights Sangam society, culture, and polity.
Epic	Manimegalai	Sittalai Sattanar	• It is a Buddhist epic about Manimegalai, the daughter of Kovalan and Madhavi. • Explores spirituality and dharma, focusing on Manimegalai's transformation into a nun. • Teaches ethics to the Chola king and emphasises Nirvana through the Kannagi temple.
Significant Work	Tirukkural	Thiruvalluvar	• A collection of 1,330 couplets divided into three sections: Virtue, Wealth, and Love. • Deals with ethical and moral teachings, making it one of the most revered texts.

Kingdoms During the Sangam Age

The three major dynasties—**Cheras, Cholas, and Pandyas**—formed the **Muvendar** (three kings). These dynasties controlled distinct regions and contributed to the political, cultural, and economic growth of Tamilakam.

Aspect	Chola Dynasty	Chera Dynasty	Pandya Dynasty
Capital Cities	Uraiyur, Kaveripattinam (Puhar)	Vanji (Karur), Muziris, Tondi	Madurai, Korkai
Famous Rulers	Karikala Chola, Elara	Cheran Senguttuvan, Imayavaramban	Aryappadai Kadantha Neduncheliyan
Major Contributions	Kallanai Dam, irrigation projects	Pattini Cult, Himalayan expedition	Pearl trade, defeat of Aryan forces
Economy	Cotton textiles, maritime trade	Roman trade, coinage	Pearl fishing, Roman emissaries
Military Campaigns	Battle of Venni, Vahaipparandalai	Conquests up to the Himalayas	Battle of Thalaiyalanganam



Chola Dynasty

- **Capital Cities:**
 - **Uraiyur:** Known for its **cotton trade**.
 - **Kaveripattinam (Puhar):** An important port city that became a hub of **maritime trade**.
- **Territorial Extent:**
 - The Chola territory extended from the **Cauvery Delta region** in modern Tamil Nadu to parts of **southern Andhra Pradesh**, between the **Pennar and Vellar Rivers**.
- **Titles of Chola Kings:**
 - **Senni, Valavan, and Killi:** Titles reflecting **valour, strength, and tradition**.
- **Notable Chola Rulers were:**

Elara (Early Chola King)

- Known for his **just and impartial rule** in **Sri Lanka**, mentioned in the **Mahavamsa**.
- Though a **conqueror**, he ruled with **fairness**, earning the respect of both **Sinhalese** and **Tamils**. His reign ended when **Dutugemunu**, a Sinhalese prince, defeated him in battle.

Karikala Chola

- **Rise to Power:**
 - Karikala emerged victorious despite facing **internal family conflicts** over succession.
- **Military Campaigns:**
 - **Battle of Venni:**
 - Defeated a **mighty confederacy** of **Chera, Pandya, and 11 minor chieftains**.
 - This battle consolidated **Chola's supremacy** in the region.
 - **Battle of Vahaipparandalai:**
 - Defeated **nine chieftains**, further strengthening his hold over the **Tamil region**.

- **Contributions to Agriculture and Infrastructure:**
 - Constructed the **Kallanai Dam** across the **Cauvery River**, one of the **oldest dams** in the world still in use.
 - Built **irrigation tanks** and canals, promoting agricultural prosperity.
- **Maritime Trade:**
 - The port city of **Puhar (Kaveripattinam)** became a **centre for foreign trade**. Merchants from **Rome and Greece** frequented the port, bringing **gold, wine, and horses**.

Chera Dynasty

- **Capital Cities:**
 - **Vanji (Karur):** Political centre of the Cheras.
 - **Tondi and Muziris:** Major ports for **Roman trade**.
- **Territorial Extent:** The Chera kingdom covered **modern-day Kerala** and **western Tamil Nadu**.
- **Titles of Chera Kings: Vanavaramban, Kuttuvan, Irumporai, and Villavar:** Reflecting **divine descent** and **warrior prowess**.
- **Notable Chera Rulers were:**

Perumchotru Udhiyan Cheralathan

- Known for his **generosity** and hospitality, supplying food to both armies during the **Mahabharata war**.

Imayavaramban Nedum Cheralathan

- Known for his **Himalayan expedition**, marking the **northern expansion** of the Chera kingdom.
- His victories are mentioned in **Pathitruvalu**, one of the Sangam literary works.

Cheran Senguttuvan

- **Military Campaigns:**
 - Led an expedition to the **Himalayas**, defeating several **northern monarchs**.
 - His achievements are recorded in **Silappathikaram**.

- Established the **Pattini Cult**, worshipping **Kannagi**, the heroine of **Silappathikaram**, as a goddess of chastity.
- **Contemporary of Gajabhagu II:**
 - Senguttuvan's relationship with the Sri Lankan king **Gajabhagu II** highlights the **interconnectedness of South India and Sri Lanka** during this period.

Pandya Dynasty

- **Capital Cities:**
 - **Madurai:** Located on the **banks of the Vaigai River**, Madurai was the political and cultural hub of the Pandyas.
 - **Korkai:** Known for **pearl fishing** and maritime trade.
- **Territorial Extent:** Covered **southern Tamil Nadu** and maintained **close trade relations** with the Romans.
- **Titles of Pandya Kings:** **Thennavar** and **Minavar**: Reflecting **their southern dominance** and **maritime prowess**.
- **Notable Pandya Rulers:**

Aryappadai Kadantha Neduncheliyan

- Defeated **Aryan forces** in a significant battle, cementing his place in Tamil history.
- Ordered the **execution of Kovalan** based on false accusations, as described in **Silappathikaram**. This act led to the **burning of Madurai** by Kannagi.

Thalaiyalanganaattu Cheruvendra Neduncheliyan

- Defeated a **coalition of Chera, Chola, and Velir chieftains** in the **battle of Thalaiyalanganam**.
- Adopted the title "**Thalaiyalanganaattu**" to commemorate his victory.

Uggira Peruvaludhi

- Last known Pandya king of the Sangam Age. His reign witnessed the beginning of the **decline of the Pandyan dynasty** due to the **Kalabhra invasion**.

Sangam Polity and Administration

Category	Details
Form of Government	• Hereditary Monarchy, with kings often taking titles that showcased their strength, such as Thennavar (Southern King) and Minavar (Warrior of the Seas).
Advisory Councils	• Kings were supported by various councils and officials: • Ministers (Amaichar): Advised on governance and policy matters. • Priests (Anthanar): Oversaw religious rituals and ceremonies. • Military Commanders (Senathipathi): Led armies and organized defence strategies. • Spies (Otrar): Gathered intelligence on internal and external matters. • Envoys (Thuthar): Managed diplomatic relations and negotiations.
Administrative Divisions	• The kingdom was divided into several units for efficient governance: • Mandalam: The largest administrative division, equivalent to a province. • Nadu: A district-level division under local chiefs. • Ur: Towns with significant trade or cultural importance. • Perur: Large villages acting as local centres of governance and agriculture. • Sirur: Small villages at the grassroots level.

	Provincial administration <pre> graph TD Mandalam["Mandalam (Province)"] --> Velanadu["Velanadu (Group of Nadus)"] Velanadu --> Nadu["Nadu (Basic unit of administration)"] Nadu --> Kottam["Kottam (Wards)"] Kottam --> Village["Village"] Village --> Sabha["Sabha"] Village --> Ur["Ur"] Sabha <--> Ur </pre>
Special Divisions	• Pattinam: Coastal towns that served as important trade hubs, such as Puhar. • Cheri: Suburbs on the outskirts of towns, often inhabited by labourers and artisans.
Revenue System	• Multiple sources of revenue ensured a steady income for the state: • Karai (Land Tax): Levied on agricultural produce and land ownership. • Ulgu (Custom Duties): Charged on goods traded through ports and trade routes. • Irai (Tribute): Annual payments or tributes from feudatory chiefs acknowledging the overlordship of kings. • Iravu (Extra Demand): Occasional additional taxes demanded from peasants during festivals or emergencies.
Military Administration	• Standing Army: Each ruler maintained a permanent army to safeguard the kingdom. • Kodimaram (War Banners): Each army had distinctive banners representing their ruler and region.

	• War Booty: Wealth and goods seized during conquests were a major source of royal income. • Training and Defense: Military commanders organized regular drills and maintained fortifications along strategic locations.
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Sangam Economy

Category	Details
Agriculture	Agriculture formed the backbone of the Sangam economy with irrigation advancements: • Crops Cultivated: Rice (staple crop), Sugarcane, Cotton, Pepper, Turmeric, Ginger, and Jackfruit (famous in Chera regions). • Irrigation Systems: Development of irrigation tanks, wells, and reservoirs. The Kallanai Dam built by Karikala Chola across the Kaveri River promoted agriculture and flood control. • Land Utilization: Forest reclamation efforts turned lands into agricultural fields, enhancing food production.
Handicrafts	Handicrafts were integral to the economy with industries like weaving, metalwork, shipbuilding, and carpentry: • Weaving: Cotton textiles from Uraiyur were highly prized in Roman markets. Both cotton and silk fabrics were woven and exported. • Metalwork: Tools, weapons, and ornaments were crafted, including bronze and iron artefacts. • Shipbuilding: Coastal towns specialized in shipbuilding for trade and military use. • Craft Centers: Important centres included Arikamedu (bead-making and ceramics), Madurai (jewellery and metalwork), and Kanchipuram (textiles).

Internal Trade	Trade within Tamil regions operated on a barter system: • Marketplaces: Both day and night markets existed, as mentioned in Maduraikanchi, trading various goods such as textiles, spices, and crafts. • Trade Practices: Exchange of goods and services without currency; bartering was common. • Salt Merchants: Known as Umanar, they facilitated the trade of essential goods, including salt.
External Trade	Tamil ports connected South India with the Roman Empire, Greece, and Southeast Asia: • Key Ports: Puhar (Kaveripattinam), Musiri, Korkai, Arikamedu, and Tondi were thriving ports for foreign trade. • Exports: Spices (pepper, turmeric, cardamom), textiles, pearls, ivory, and precious stones. • Imports: Gold, Roman wine, and horses were imported to meet the demands of the elite. • Roman Influence: Discovery of Roman coins in Tamil Nadu highlights robust trade with the Roman Empire. These coins were used both for commerce and as ornaments.
Roman Coins	Roman coins reflect the significance of Indo-Roman trade: • Types: Gold and silver coins have been unearthed across Tamil Nadu. • Usage: Coins served dual purposes: currency for trade and adornment. • Economic Impact: The inflow of Roman gold enriched the Tamil economy, facilitating urban growth in port cities.  Roman Coins found in Tamil Nadu Sometimes even worn as Jewellery

Revenue System	The state's income was generated through taxes, trade duties, and war booty: • Land Tax (Karai): Primary source of revenue collected from cultivators. • Custom Duties (Ulgu): Imposed on goods traded through ports. • Tribute (Irai): Paid by feudatory chiefs to the king. • Forced Gift (Iravu): Extra demands made from peasants during emergencies or festivals. • War Booty: Seized treasures from defeated kingdoms boosted the treasury.
Trade Terminology	Several trade-related terms reflect the complexity of the economy: • Vanikan: Trader or merchant. • Chattan and Nigama: Guilds or merchant associations regulating trade. • Umanar: Salt merchants responsible for transporting and selling salt. • Chattu: Mobile merchants who travelled between towns and ports, engaging in commerce.
Economic Prosperity	Economic prosperity led to the growth of urban centres and increased demand for luxury goods: • Urban Growth: Coastal towns such as Puhar flourished due to maritime trade. • Luxury Goods: The elite class demanded imported goods like Roman wine and horses, while the middle class purchased local textiles and spices. • Impact on Society: Wealth generated from trade led to social stratification, with traders and merchants gaining higher status.

Sangam Society

Social Structure:

Tolkappiyam describes a **five-fold land division** (Panchitanai).

Land Type	Deity	Occupation	Inhabitants
Kurinji (Hills)	Murugan	Hunting, honey collection	Kuravar, Vetar
Mullai (Pastoral)	Vishnu	Cattle rearing	Eyinar, Maravar
Marudam (Agricultural)	Indra	Agriculture	Ayar, Vellalar
Neydal (Coastal)	Varuna	Fishing, salt production	Paratavar, Ulavar
Palai (Desert)	Korravai	Robbery	Maravar, Valayar

Caste System during the Sangam Age

Caste	Role/Occupation	Description
Arasar	Ruling class	Kings, chieftains, and local rulers were responsible for governance, law, and protection.
Anthanar	Priests and religious leaders	Conducted rituals, presided over temples, and advised rulers on spiritual matters.
Vanigar	Traders and merchants	Engaged in internal and external trade; controlled markets and facilitated foreign trade with Romans and Greeks.
Vellalar	Agriculturists	Landowners and farmers responsible for agricultural activities; managed irrigation and production.

Position of Women in the Sangam Age

The position of women in the Sangam period was relatively **progressive**, offering them freedom in various aspects of life. However, societal expectations and customs also shaped their roles, especially among the upper classes.

Women's Autonomy

- **Freedom in Partner Selection:** Women had the liberty to choose their life partners. **Love marriages** were common, and relationships were often based on mutual affection.
- **Participation in Literary and Cultural Activities:** Women played active roles in **literature, poetry, music, and dance**. They were not confined to domestic life and were often respected for their artistic talents.
- **Education:** Although not all women were educated, some **women poets and scholars** made significant contributions to Sangam literature.
- **Property Rights:** In some instances, women were allowed to hold and inherit property, but this was more common in aristocratic families.
- **Famous Women Poets:**
 - **Avvaiyar:** Known for her moral and philosophical poems, she is revered even today.
 - **Nachchellaiyar:** Another talented poet who contributed to Tamil literature.
 - **Kakkaipadiniyar:** Known for her verses on love and virtue.

Practices among Upper Classes

- **Sati:** The practice of **Sati (self-immolation)**, though not widely prevalent, was observed among certain aristocratic families. Widows would voluntarily or under societal pressure immolate themselves on the pyre of their deceased husbands.
- **Karpu (Chastity):** A chaste life (Karpu) was regarded as the highest virtue for women. Loyalty to one's husband was considered paramount, and widows were often expected to lead austere lives.

Sangam Religion

The Sangam period witnessed a blend of **indigenous beliefs** and **emerging religious practices**, with a focus on nature worship and hero worship.

Primary Deity: Murugan

- **Murugan** (also known as **Seyon**) was the **chief deity** worshipped during this period. He was associated with **war, valor, and youth** and was honored with six abodes called **Arupadai Veedu**.
- Murugan was closely connected with the **hilly regions (Kurinji)**, where hunting and pastoral communities worshipped him as their protector.

Other Deities

- **Vishnu (Mayon)**: He was worshipped as a guardian deity, particularly in agricultural communities.
- **Indra**: Revered as the **god of rain and thunder**, ensuring prosperity and agricultural abundance.
- **Varuna**: Associated with the **seas and oceans**, Varuna was the deity of the coastal regions.
- **Korravai**: The **goddess of war** and victory, worshipped by warrior communities.

Hero Stones (Nadu Kal)

- **Hero stones** were erected in memory of **warriors** who lost their lives in battle or during cattle raids. These stones were often inscribed with the names of the fallen warriors and occasionally had carvings depicting their heroic deeds.
- Hero stone worship was a form of **ancestor worship**, and these stones became sacred symbols of valour and sacrifice.

Decline of the Sangam Age

The **end of the Sangam period** marked a transitional phase in the political and social structure of Tamil Nadu. The invasion of the **Kalabhras** disrupted the established order, leading to a period of uncertainty and cultural change.

Kalabhra Invasion

- The **Kalabhras**, a tribal dynasty, **invaded Tamil Nadu** around the **3rd century CE** and ruled for over **250 years**.

- They **disrupted the traditional political structure** of the Tamil kingdoms, displacing the Cheras, Cholas, and Pandyas. This period has been termed as the '**dark age**' by earlier historians due to the lack of substantial records and the decline of established social norms.

Impact of the Kalabhra Rule

- The Kalabhra period was marked by **political instability**, causing the **disruption of trade** and **economic activities**.
- **Buddhism and Jainism** gained prominence during this period, as the Kalabhras were believed to have supported these religions over traditional Hindu practices.
- Despite the political turmoil, **literature thrived** with the composition of works such as the **Tirukkural**, which is considered a literary masterpiece even today.

Re-emergence of Power

- The **Pallavas** and **Pandyas** eventually reasserted control over Tamil Nadu by the **6th century CE**, marking the end of the Kalabhra interregnum.
- This re-establishment of power led to the emergence of larger **state societies** under the Pallavas in **northern Tamil Nadu** and the **Pandyas** in the **southern region**.